We galloped through the medical—cardiovascular, biomechanics, blood, urine, electro cardiogram, x-rays and scans—with the various specialists. Then Senor Corral got his hands on me for a physical examination. He was particularly interested in a left metatarsal and a right scaphoid bone. We were done and dusted in just over two hours. A cameraman from Real Madrid's television station followed us up and down the corridors of the hospital before getting the door shut in his face each time I went into a clinic for a particular test. Everyone seemed to be grinning from ear to ear: the specialists, the staff, the other patients, the cameraman with the black eye. Could we have a photo taken? Could we have an autograph? It all seemed very relaxed. The doctors had been given my complete medical records from fifteen years at Old Trafford and I'm sure they'd done their homework. Dr Corral himself gave the impression of knowing exactly what he was looking for. And was happy enough when he found it. Someone told me afterwards what he'd told the waiting press:

'David esta como nuevo. Fisicamente esta perfecto.'

He reckoned I was in half-decent shape, then. And that my pen hand was up to signing on Real's dotted line. I went to the hotel, the Tryp Fenix, to meet up with Victoria, Brooklyn and Mum. I think the fans who'd started to gather outside the Fenix were as excited about Victoria as they were about the new soccer player in town. She seemed tense, though: she'd been driven round the new city, looking for somewhere to call home. What we were about to take on had started to sink in. Me and Brooklyn had time for a little kickabout on the terrace of our suite. I wonder how much of all this he'll remember once he's older.

The cars came back at five o'clock to take us to the Bernabeu. The stadium was just a short drive up the main road through the early evening traffic: Real have built their home ground on Madrid's equivalent of Fifth Avenue. I'd been there before, of course, as a Manchester United player but, as we swung in through the gates, I didn't recognize much. The place was a building site: cranes arching in from the road, diggers and dump trucks bumping along between the piles of supplies. José Angel Sanchez, Real's Marketing Director, told me the club were having to remodel the stand on the side of the ground where the players come out:

'When Santiago Bernabeu built this stadium in the forties, he put the presidential suites in the stand opposite the one with the players' facilities. It was supposed to say: our boardroom won't ever be in competition with our dressing room. Now, though, UEFA Champions League regulations say we